

Final Case Study

WI25_CO5711_Moen

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Introduction

In this paper, I will write an assessment of the counseling sessions between Ellen and the Author. This assessment consists of three states: encounter, engagement, and disengagement.

In the encounter phase, we meet the counselee and find out what their reason for coming to see us is. We hear their history, and we try to make a diagnosis. I will try to see all these aspects in the session with Ellen.

In the Engagement phase, we explore the real problem in depth. We are engaging with the counselee, and are trying to find out what the problem is, and how to address the problem with the solution. I will assess this with Ellen.

In the Disengagement phase, we look at our progress and assess what else must be done and arrange a referral if necessary. This is the end of counseling.

Encounter

The counseling session with Ellen starts off with her making small contact with the pastor, as the author says that “the pastor knew her only slightly” and that Ellen and her husband were “new to the congregation” (p. 105).

Assessment: from this we can tell that the pastor will have to learn much more about the counselee. From this information, we know that Ellen is married, but we don’t know if this marriage is good or bad. Also, we know that she is a congregant of the church, which helps us understand that she may know Christ and is at least trying to be a Christian.

Ellen was “somewhat agitated” and the pastor sensed “some conflict between them in this brief encounter” (that is between the husband and Ellen).

Assessment: from this we can tell there is something wrong between the husband and the wife. The pastor made a good observation here because this is a good evaluation of the Encounter phase of the counseling sessions.

She did not “give any indication of the nature of her concerns.” “She did, however, betray a mild degree of urgency when she stated that she hoped he would be able to see her within the next few days.” “She would make herself available at any time to accommodate his schedule.”

Assessment: from this we can tell that she has a true urgency in the situation she is in. When her voice gives no indication of concerns, she may be very stressed and trying to control herself. However, if she was truly in a panic, this voice would betray her feelings and truly show all her emotions. Thus, we know we have at hand a strong situation that is serious, but is not a panic and alarm situation. We know this because she wants to make herself available at any time and in the next few days. This shows that she really wants help, and an important thing to note is that she trusts the Pastor and feels that the pastor can help. She feels that the pastor is the right person to contact for this problem and is seeking the pastor’s help.

In the first session, she arrives 10 minutes early. She says that she “hoped she was not imposing on his time” and “apologized for calling the church since she was not a member and had only attended on a few occasions.”

Assessment: this shows that she is serious in getting help in counseling. One of the most important things about counseling is having the counselee be serious and willing to be helped during counseling, and this is the case with Ellen, as she arrived 10 minutes early and is very apologetic. The apologetic attitude is a cultural attitude and shows that she is trying to be kind and normal and respectful of the pastor. This is a very good sign for the future sessions.

It is revealed that she “recently had an abortion and was experiencing considerable guilt over it” (p. 107). Then, she requires a “partial hysterectomy” and would never have children. She felt “anger toward her husband,” who talked her into the abortion. She has “sadness” and feels “her own complicity.”

Assessment: this is very difficult news to hear, and the pastor needs to comfort Ellen and listen to all her thoughts and situation. I think that if I were to hear this, I would be very surprised because I have not encountered many real life situations like this. This is also a difficult situation because Christians are generally opposed to abortions, and for a Christian to do an abortion is a source of conflict in the heart of the pastor as well as Ellen. Truly, the truth is that the sadness and the guilt and the lack of children may be the consequences of this decision. Whether it was a sin or not we do not know, but a theologian may actually say she sinned and is facing the punishment of God, while the pastor would say we don’t know - we just need to pray; and the counselor will say, God is always on our side and we need to continue to seek the Lord and do what is right and that God will forgive us if we do something wrong.

Engagement

Ellen says she thinks the pastor thinks she “is an awful person for what [she] has done.” She can’t expect God to “forgive [her].” The pastor replies, “I don’t think you are an awful person...how awful you feel. You have obviously failed yourself...and God...[and feel] you don’t deserve ever to be forgiven.

Assessment: from this interaction, we see an exchange of understanding of each other and sympathy. Ellen is trying to understand and think about what the pastor thinks and the pastor is reflecting back what Ellen thinks. I think the pastor did a great job in this situation, because the moment that we hear very dramatic news, we need to reflect back the thoughts and reaffirm their

emotions and feelings. The pastor sympathized and empathized with Ellen, and thus, made Ellen feel welcome and comfortable about herself and Ellen feels heard.

Ellen then says, "That's for sure!" She even marched "in pro-life rallies." The pastor replies, "Who is this God you have failed?"

Assessment: this is a very good sign from what Ellen says. We can infer that Ellen feels heard and that she agrees with the pastor. She feels disgusted with herself because she was pro-life and feels that she failed God. She is viewing herself negatively and regrets her decision. But the Pastor says something that is very unexpected and strong in force - he asks, "Who is this God" that you are imagining? God is a good God, who forgives a thousand times over. You are viewing God incorrectly - to see him as a judging God who wants perfection. We know God to be a God who seeks the lost and the sinner, not the righteous. The pastor is now bringing in Theology into the counseling session and showing a correct understanding of God.

Ellen says, "The same as your God." The pastor responds, "What is he like? How do you relate to him?" Ellen experienced a lawful God with no grace or forgiveness. She prayed for forgiveness, but felt no better.

Assessment: from this, we can tell that there is something underneath the surface - that Ellen has an issue that is underneath the surface that is causing her not to be able to view God correctly. This is something that the pastor will have to investigate as we go on into the further sessions. It is clear that Ellen is viewing God in a lawful way with no grace or love - this can potentially be because she grew up in a perfectionist type of home, and we shall see this more clearly soon and later.

The pastor says that “forgiveness is a process..feelings are involved” and the pastor wants to know why she is stuck in this process. The pastor wants to know why she thinks God has such high standards.

Ellen replies that “God is God, and she is only human.” She goes on to tell of the great stresses she has with her marriage, career, and Christianity, when her husband doesn’t have those stresses. God doesn’t understand Ellen or sympathize with her weakness.

The pastor responds that God does not just look with “disgust and anger.” The pastor speaks of the incarnation, and that God does not walk away when you fail him.

Ellen responds that she doesn’t feel God with her.

Assessment: I feel that the pastor is doing a good job counseling. The first thing the pastor does, is to clarify that forgiveness is a process. And one of the things that I hope the pastor understands is that because it is a process, we need to step through the process step-by-step and understand Ellen completely. We cannot expect Ellen to fully forgive so fast. So instead of trying to correct Ellen, as the pastor does, I think it is important to sympathize with Ellen. I think that is the whole point of this conversation - that God does not sympathize with Ellen or humans. And the pastor is not helping by teaching and correcting - sometimes humans and Ellen just need someone to listen to them and understand their situation. I think the most important thing in counseling is just to provide a listening ear.

However, one thing the pastor does well is to pinpoint the problem in Ellen. Ellen clearly has perfectionist type attitudes and the pastor pinpoints this by saying that God does not have unfair standards that are too high. Also, the pastor makes an inference or a guess at Ellen’s point of view, and says that God does not look in “disgust or anger.” I think this is a controversial statement because we do not know clearly what Ellen is thinking at this state, and we may be

looking too far into the situation to say something like that. However, the pastor does a good job in probing the situation, even though he may be a little bit incorrect or off. And Ellen responds well when she admits that she doesn't feel God with her.

As you can see, Ellen is completely trusting of the pastor and is engaged in the therapy. She feels that she can trust the pastor and is compliant.

The pastor asks if there was a time God was with Ellen.

Assessment: this is a fantastic question because this is a solution-oriented question and answer. In this question, we see the pastor looking at the positive and focusing on the things in the past that are meaningful and good. By doing this, we are able to focus on what is good and have Ellen improve, rather than just dwell in the bad.

Ellen thinks of her childhood, and when there were "times of peace and calm." These moments she felt "God's presence and love, peace, and beauty." This came to an end when she was eleven they attended a small church. Her parents became less fun-loving and more rigid in rules. Her mother seemed to "withdraw from Ellen" after church. She felt "like an orphan." Her father was a "disciplinarian." Uncaring and authoritarian. Never satisfied with what she did. "Never showing appreciation."

Then she talks of her marriage. Both of them wanted professional achievements. Children are the biggest conflict. Ellen wanted to have children. The husband, Rick, didn't want children because he didn't want a distraction of his career. They fought, and got an abortion due to "her husband's pressure." She would lose childbearing.

Assessment: this is the best insight we have into the reason why Ellen is so perfectionist. As can be seen in the description of the father, the father is uncaring and disciplinarian. This shows that Ellen had to perform in order to get the love of the father. This is the source of

perfectionism. This is why she focuses so much on her career over children, and why she attracted a similar-minded person - Rick. This reason for perfectionism will shed light onto the reason why she has problems today and why she fears God and views him as a Law and Order type of God. Why doesn't Ellen think that God can forgive her? The reason is because she is a perfectionist due to her dad during childhood.

Ellen says she doesn't know how to cope with her feelings. She feels guilt the most. She also has anger toward herself and her husband.

Disengagement

We conclude the matter with the final session. Ellen starts explaining how she feels about the marriage. She is disappointed in the marriage and how she is not receiving a loving and caring husband as she deserves. However, the pastor talks right at her and says, "Think about the possibility that he never changes. If he never changes, what will you do?" She didn't want to accept this possibility because she felt she deserved a loving husband. However, she realized that she was only hurting herself by requiring and forcing a condition on her husband.

Thus, Ellen realized that she needed to let go of her husband and give him freedom - even freedom to remain in sin and not change. This letting go would free her and allow her to finally be happy - to be happy regardless of the circumstances or how her husband is.

Also, Ellen talked about how hard it is to forgive both her husband and herself for the abortion. The pastor talks her through it and shows her that she is having a difficult time but that it is okay and reasonable to be doing so.

They end the session by talking about how they are finishing up their sessions for the last time. Ellen is a little bit sad because the sessions are ending because she felt so comforted and so happy doing these sessions. These sessions must have really helped Ellen.

Assessment: Ellen has a great final session. She really discovers the solution to her marriage and to her forgiveness problem. The solution is to let go and let God. The solution is to not require change and not require conditions on her life and her happiness. Thus, she is able to be happy regardless of the circumstances and be free. This means that even if her husband doesn't change, she can be happy. And even though she made a mistake doing the abortion, she can still be happy. Requirements are a law that prevents us from being free and from being happy. The pastor was very smart in pointing this out, and pointed out the most crucial requirement for Ellen's happiness. I believe this is a lesson for all of us and that we should all be happy regardless of the circumstances.

The other thing that we learned was that Ellen was not able to forgive easily. We need to sympathize with her and walk her through the stages of forgiveness slowly - we cannot rush the process. And no matter how much theory and wisdom we give her, she must step through the process at her own pace and have a natural way of forgiving. Thus, it may take longer than the small number of sessions they have for her to forgive this huge life decision.

In conclusion, I learned so much about counseling and believe the pastor did an excellent job in counseling. I believe the pastor could do an even better job by including psychology and modern theories about the brain when he does his therapy. For example, secular ideas about forgiveness and the theories on the guilt and regret that come with guilt, could help with a better understanding of Ellen's situation, rather than just viewing it as a spiritual problem that is strictly Biblical.